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Jimmy Heath

Saxophonist and composer Jimmy Heath has played an important role in jazz for six decades. He received an NEA Jazz Masters award in 2003 and his compositions are among the best of the jazz standards.

Jimmy was interviewed in New York City on September 8, 2014, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm at St. Peter's Church inside the chapel with Mr. Jimmy Heath, composer and arranger, jazz master. I wanted to congratulate you on your career —

JH: Thank you very much, Monk.

MR: and your new book.

JH: Thank you again.

MR: You said some really neat things. I actually thought I invented a word and I saw you use it in your book, called "melodize."

JH: Melodize.

MR: You said you melodized and you wrote the melodies of the beat of life.

JH: Yeah, well melodize. I've heard that word before from others. So I don't know where it came from but it floats around so anybody can use it, as you said you did.

MR: Yeah. Do you think your composing changed over the years from when you started writing in the late 40s until now, because of life?

JH: Well you know, I think I've gotten better at everything because I practice all the time and I'm writing all the time. And I think the Macintosh/Apple computer helped me to do a lot of editing and to present my music pretty much like I want it before I take it to the people with the breath of life and then it comes to really, fruition.

MR: Are you a Finale user?

JH: Yes.

MR: So am I. And it's interesting, you can almost get used to the way it sounds coming out of the computer and then when you put it in front of people it's like, oh there's that missing element.

JH: Yes. It comes to life. Yeah.

MR: I was really happy to see you talk about your relationship with the Adderleys, which was — Cannonball was like a musical hero of mine. What was it about him that —

JH: Well I consider Cannonball Adderley as a country preacher in his deliverance of his melodic performances. You know he had the south in his playing as well as the science. And people who have that, they've got the whole thing as far as I'm concerned. Coltrane

had it. My brother Percy had it. He was born in North Carolina and I was born in Philadelphia. And Percy could play a blues after leaving the MJQ [Modern Jazz Quartet] and playing with the Heath brothers he started to play what I call the baby bass, which was something that Ray Brown created. It was a cello body strung up like a bass. And Percy could play the blues and get it over every time. Because he was born in North Carolina in the south. There's something about being born in the south that, at that time, of course people are born everywhere now and can play the blues.

MR: You said something, just in what you said about the blues makes me wonder — you were talking about how jazz is sometimes now thought of as the "white man's music." And what is the reason for that?

JH: I didn't say it was the white man's music. I said the white man is claiming it for his music —

MR: Okay.

JH: — but it was created by African-Americans. And there were a few whites, even at that time, you know, Bix Beiderbecke and people back there, they were in that same mode. But the majority of the performers were African-Americans. Now all over the world there are people — you know I've been all over and I hear people playing like Sonny Rollins or Coltrane or Dizzy or whoever, from here, coming from all over the world. They've heard that music and they've absorbed some of the improvisational language.

MR: Do you consider yourself — you grew up in the bebop era.

JH: Yeah. I also grew up in the swing era.

MR: Right. So where does your heart still lay?

JH: Well I think I still love the fact that even bebop swung. I still like a pulse in my music, and I'm not a meter maid. I'm not changing meters from 9/8 and this and that and all — 5/4 and this, 7, all these meters. I mean I walk in 4/4 and I live in 4/4. And I think all of those meters can be applied to 4/4.

MR: So that you could write a 7/8 figure but still stick in 4.

JH: Yeah.

MR: Yeah.

JH: It would just hang over the bar line.

MR: You know I was interested in one passage where you were writing, I think it was 1949, and you were on the same bill as the Orioles. And you saw the beginning of R&B, rock & roll, Motown, all that stuff. And I wonder if you and your fellow musicians saw something coming that was worrisome?

JH: No I didn't see anything that was worrisome because we had different genres, and we still have different genres of music. So I didn't have a problem with people, quartets singing, Orioles singing songs, "What Are You Doing New Years," or whatever the song. That

was the one that was popular. But I was with Dizzy's band when the Orioles had it — they were the headliners. And Dizzy's band was not. We were on the program with them. So you know, there is still different genres, and what they call R&B, rock & roll, or whatever, they all have some close — they borrowed some things from the jazz idiom too.

MR: Did you ever look upon guys like Sam the Man Taylor and King Curtis and wonder, I wonder if I should try to be getting into that studio business.

JH: Well no. I played behind King Curtis in Philadelphia. See I had a student by the name of Sam Reid, who ran the band at the Uptown Theater in Philadelphia, where all the R&B shows were held. So I played behind — the one that played the guitar and the tenor, not Sam the Man Taylor. I think he was one of big bands.

MR: I think he was too.

JH: No I'm talking about the other guy. He got killed.

MR: Oh King Curtis?

JH: King Curtis. Yeah he got killed over in Holland.

MR: Yeah. You know since the 80s and so forth you have garnered some wonderful awards, some commissions, honorary degrees. Do you sometimes think I could have used some of that in the 1960s?

JH: Well you know as far as — I feel very fortunate to have made a living off of playing what I like. Not a lot of people can say that. You have to compromise, and I have at one point when we were with Columbia Records we compromised and added some things to sell more product. But basically I would say I've been very fortunate to play the music I loved all my life and made a good living.

MR: And written some lasting compositions too.

JH: I think so. I hope so.

MR: Do you get — you know let's say a Jimmy Heath song, let's say it showed up in the *Real Book*. Did you ever get any compensation for that?

JH: Not for those gangsters who made those books. But as far as the legitimate books, you know, I get — Jamey Aebersold or something like that. Or the guy in California who put three or four of my songs in his book. I can't think of his name. He makes big books about songs from the jazz world.

MR: Right. And the *Real Book* has now been made legal sort of.

JH: Yeah, well who is the publisher?

MR: Sher.

JH: Yeah I get money from him for my songs. Danny Sher?

MR: I'm not sure what his first name is.

JH: Okay. Sher Music.

MR: When you go to the mail every day, this is sort of a personal question, but what kind of income might you receive that could be a surprise to you, from things you've done?

JH: Well I think the biggest surprise was when I was sampled by a rapper by the name of Nas, whose father, Olu Dara, was a trumpet player. And Nas sampled me and, you know, I got big checks from his composition that he calls "One Love." But all he used was a few bars.

MR: Of your tenor playing?

JH: No. Of the composition. It was on a suite that I wrote for Billy Higgins called "Smiling Billy's Suite." And one part had Stanley Cowell playing the kalimba, the African thumb piano. And my brother Percy played on the bass. And that composition was the one that was sampled the most.

MR: Very interesting. I want to talk about jazz education a little bit. You had said that playing with too much technique or showing off won't usually speak to a lot of people. And I wonder if that's not what a lot of jazz educators teach young musicians to do, is to play with a lot of technique.

JH: Well they have to have some technique, but they go overboard sometimes with that you know. And my opinion about improvisational music is to have science and soul, those two elements. If you've got those two elements equally you're okay. But if you're overboard with one — with the science, you've got too much science and not enough feeling, it doesn't work. Because the average person hasn't studied all the sequences and all the things that you are playing. They don't know what that is. They think you are practicing, which you are, instead of standing there and improvising. And you have to have a feeling to do that. And that's the soul part, which is a natural ability to try to lyricize what you're playing. Sing to the people. The greatest improvisers of all time knew how to do that. Johnny Hodges didn't have a problem going around scientists or laymen and getting over. Because he sang. He made the saxophone sing. Ben Webster didn't have a problem with that. You know? And then some of the masters other than those two, like Coltrane — I knew when Trane could play ballads and touch people you know. Sonny Rollins has such a rhythmic feel to his playing that he never had a problem getting over. So those elements, the rhythmic feel, the soulful feeling, the art of singing through your instrument and telling the story. Lester Young used to say, "What is your story?" Prez. "You have to have a story." So you're telling the audience your story musically. And your story is not high tech science. That's not the story they can understand. That may be your story, but you minimize your audience. You know, like if you like Gene Ammons, Gene Ammons could play anywhere and people loved him. Because he could sing with the horn. And there are a lot of musicians who are like that.

MR: How do you tell an 18-year-old college freshman how to put more soul — because I've got this problem where I teach.

JH: They're listening — and they're listening to too much soul sometimes you know. People who don't really play with a lot of science, the popular ones — Kenny G — they listen to that. Bony James. They listen to that and they know that those people can get over. So they give up. They have what they want to do, their expression, to please an audience. That's a different thing. If you can keep your idea of what music should be like and still get over, that's when you've reached a very happy compromise with an audience. Ballads are very important. Love songs. Because everybody wants to make love.

MR: Well said. I've had a debate sometimes with musicians about, are there wrong notes when you improvise?

JH: Well the way I look at improvisation, you know you can step out of the basic chord pattern if you make the connections. In other words, life is about connections. Everything musically is about connections. Socially it's about connections. Connections is one of the biggest words in the English language. You've got to make a connection. And that's what I'm talking about. If you see, like I remember Theodore "Fats" Navarro. Great trumpeter. And Fats used to play — if a woman walked in with a red dress on [scats] he'd play the "Lady in Red." Because he's trying to pull this broad or something. You know what I mean? They're trying to — he was trying to communicate and connect and that's what I'm talking about. An 18-year-old has to connect too, to his girlfriends. It has nothing to do with age. But he has to first have an experience. If he hasn't had enough experiences sometimes, he's just learning the scientific part of the music. You've got to learn something about the emotional part. You've got to feel that. And there's a lot of young people who come up and they got that feeling right away. And other ones, they're going for the science and they don't get it 'til maybe later, a feeling of humanness, being a human being to communicate with other human beings. You don't need a Geiger counter to tell what you're playing. Oh he's playing a F sharp minor ninth with a raised oop boop boop boop boop. You know? Who cares. How did it affect me in my heart, in my mind, in my body. "Three Ears." I wrote a piece called "Three Ears" with a symphony orchestra, and that was the premise of that. That the mind has an ear, the body has an ear, and the heart has an ear. That's the three ears. And if you get somebody to hear your music with all those three ears, you're going to be okay.

MR: Oh, that's terrific. Sometimes when I think about the history of jazz it has moved so fast it seems like. And I was remembering some of the things that Coltrane and Ornette Coleman did in the 60s. And now that seems like, wow, what is that, 50 years ago. I wonder what your reaction was to records like "Ascension" and free jazz.

JH: Well I played "Ascension" once.

MR: You played it once?

JH: And then I didn't play it no more. I didn't like "Ascension." I liked Coltrane's ballad playing. I liked — his greatest composition to me is "Naima." As beautiful as Bach, Beethoven, anybody, Tchaikovsky, anybody. It's one of the greatest melodies ever written. That's what I like. I like to hear him swing on swing tunes. But "Ascension" sounded like a big band warming up before they went on the stage. Everybody warming up. It's too many voices to hear and distinguish anything. And when I studied with Professor Rudolph Schramm from Leipzig, Germany. And he told me about the three different ways, or three counterpoint lines. You can't hear but two or three. And if everybody's playing like that it's just too dense.

MR: Very dense. I'm curious as to what was the circumstances that you played it? Because how much of it was a song? Wasn't there just a little [scats] —

JH: I don't know. I didn't like that one. I've got plenty of Coltrane records I love.

MR: Oh you mean you played the record once.

JH: Yeah.

MR: I'm sorry.

JH: I played the record once and I was done with it. And even Mingus, I heard he said the same thing, it sounded like everybody in the practice room warming up to go on the stage. There's no distinctive melody there. And what is music? Now we've got music that is words and a rhythm and no melody and no harmony. And that is not music to me. It's music by the kids. They think it's music. Every generation has their time. My brother went to his death, Percy, told me, "Aww that ain't gonna last." I say, "Yes it is Percy." Just like I was listening to Glenn Miller on the TV last night. Because I heard that when I was a kid. They were trying to get money on PBS. So they were playing the big band era. So then they were playing the Four Brothers, then they played Lionel Hampton "Flying Home." You know. Because I heard that when I was a kid so it's going to be with you. You may be educated enough to leave that and go to something else, but you're still going to remember that. Because you were raised up with that. So that's what I was telling Percy man. Rap, they're still going. He's been dead since 2005. And that's —

MR: It's still here.

JH: Yeah that music, or whatever they call it. But you know the artistic world now, through all the arts, paintings, music and everything, abscess paintings, abscess music. They call it abstract. I call it abscess. I'm done. And I'm done stepped on a lot of people's toes and I've said enough. This is my opinion and this is Monk, and now we're going to warm up for the performance.

MR: Thank you. It's been a pleasure talking to you, and I've enjoyed your music and maybe we can do Part II someday. You know, before you go, we are here for Joe Wilder. Do you

have a Joe Wilder — I mean I consider myself very lucky that I got to play with him a few times and book him some gigs. I just wonder what your —

JH: Well I had him on a couple of my recordings. Joe Wilder had what I was talking about with Johnny Hodges and people like that. He had a gorgeous musical sound. The sound of music. That means a lot to me. And Joe Wilder had a sound that would touch you. He had a great trumpet sound. Fats Navarro was one. Clifford Brown. They had sounds. But Joe Wilder was very special in that regards.

MR: Yeah. All right. Thank you Mr. Heath.

JH: All right.